

Staff Product Manager: Final Round Case Study

 this packet may seem long! No fear: it's mostly customer quotes and other supporting evidence to use

Context

NewtonX is a B2B research company that connects clients with verified experts to answer high-stakes business questions. The core pitch is quality: every expert is verified against the specific research topic, so clients can trust the data enough to put it in front of their board.

How the business works today:

The core product is expert-verified research data. Clients come to NewtonX with a business question, and NewtonX designs, fields, and delivers research against a screened expert audience. Strategic Insights (SI) is a high-value add-on where NewtonX's research team provides full-service analysis, synthesis, and strategic recommendations on top of the data—akin to a data scientist and consultant rolled into one. SI projects typically run 3-8 weeks with price points of \$30K-\$150K+. SI is not the whole business, but it's where the biggest deals and deepest client relationships live.

Hub is NewtonX's platform product. It currently supports analysis and visualization. The vision: turn Hub into a self-serve research platform that combines synthetic (AI-generated) and human research to deliver results at a pace that matches how fast decisions actually get made. Hub is where NewtonX's future growth potential lives.

Unit economics to keep in mind: NewtonX pays an average of ~\$50 per expert interaction (interview, survey response, consultation). On top of that, there's \$50 in internal overhead per interaction (matching, screening, QA, delivery; a lot of human labor). These costs matter when you think about pricing and margin.

The Product: Self-Serve Research on Hub

NewtonX leadership has greenlit investment in a self-serve research experience within Hub. The vision:

A client types a business question into Hub. The system generates a **research brief** that scopes the question, identifies relevant expert segments, and proposes a research approach. From there, the client can immediately get a **synthesized research memo** built by AI, and then escalate to human expert validation when they need higher confidence.

There are two things we're selling here, and we want clients doing both:

1. **The Survey:** An AI-generated research survey that takes a raw business question and turns it into a structured research plan. This is the *input* to research, not the output. It scopes the question, identifies the right expert audiences, and frames what the research will answer. This is fast, cheap, and high-volume. Think of it as the "thinking partner" that helps a client figure out what they actually need to know.
2. **The Research Output:** A synthesized research memo that answers the client's question. The key design question you'll need to address: how does the product handle the gap between "fast AI-generated answer" and "fully validated, expert-backed research that a client can put in front of their board"? NewtonX's value has always been verification and rigor. The self-serve product needs to move fast without sacrificing trust.

The strategic bet: if we give clients a fast, low-friction way to explore research questions, they'll naturally pull through to deeper, higher-confidence research as their stakes increase, creating an adoption loop that feeds the core research business (and SI) rather than cannibalizing it.

Your Assignment

You are the Staff PM responsible for bringing self-serve research on Hub from concept to launched product. You are strongly encouraged to use whatever tools you wish to prepare this. Prepare a **30-minute presentation** (with 15 minutes of Q&A) covering:

1. **User Feedback Synthesis:** What are the critical insights from the attached user feedback? What should we build based on what users *need* (not necessarily what they say they want)?
2. **Product Plan:** What does the MVP look like? What's in, what's out, and why? What is the phased roadmap beyond MVP?
3. **[think on] Go-to-Market Plan:** How do we position, price, and sell this product? Who are the launch customers? How does this interact with SI sales motions? You do not need to devote much of the presentation to this but it should inform other components.
4. **Cross-Functional Execution:** What do you need from other teams? What specific questions would you ask each team, and how would you align their priorities with this initiative? Assume you cannot do everything yourself. Map out what you own vs. what you delegate, and how you ensure it gets done.
5. **Prototype:** something interactive to show off core concepts and demonstrate the overall flow. We should be able to walk through it independently.

Time guidance: This should take approximately 4-5 hours to prepare. We are not looking for perfect outputs but good directional reads. We are looking for sharp thinking, clear prioritization, and the ability to separate signals from noise. We're more interested in understanding how you think than in polished outputs. Feel free to keep it lightweight

A note on this brief: Everything above is context, not gospel. The product framing, the strategic bet, even the distinction between surveys and research outputs: these are starting points, not settled decisions. If the user feedback or your own judgment tells you something here is wrong, incomplete, or poorly framed, say so. We want to see how you think, not how well you can organize our assumptions back to us. Please actively show us what you choose to cut.

DELIVERABLE REQUIREMENTS

Prepare a **30-minute presentation** addressing:

1. **Feedback Synthesis** (~5 min): What are the 3-4 most important insights from the user feedback? Which feedback did you deprioritize and why?
2. **Product Plan** (~10 min): What's the MVP? What's the phased roadmap? What are the key product decisions and tradeoffs?
3. **Go-to-Market** (~5 min): Positioning, target launch customers, pricing approach, and how self-serve research interacts with SI sales motions.
4. **Cross-Functional Execution Map** (~10 min): For each team (Sales, SI, Engineering, Marketing, Ops), what do you need from them? What specific questions would you ask? How do you align their incentives with this initiative, meaning what's in it for them? What do you own directly vs. delegate?

Then allow for Q&A time during the rest of the session.

Format: Any format you prefer. Slides, a written doc, a whiteboard, whatever communicates your thinking most clearly.

Time to prepare: ~4-5 hours. We value sharp thinking over polish. **We also appreciate that you're putting real time into this. Please reach out with any questions**

PART 1: USER FEEDBACK PACKET

The following is fictional feedback. Not all feedback is equally relevant.

User 1: Sarah Chen, VP of Market Intelligence, Enterprise SaaS Company (~8,000 employees) *Has commissioned 6 SI projects with NewtonX over the past 2 years.*

"I love what NewtonX delivers. The quality is unmatched. But here's my problem: by the time I get the final report, the strategic window has moved. My CEO asks me a question on Monday and I need a defensible answer by Friday. Right now, NewtonX gives me a defensible answer in 5 weeks. I need something in between. Give me a directional answer in 2 days that I can use for internal planning, and then let me upgrade to a fully validated version if the decision goes to the board. I'd pay separately for both."

User 2: Marcus Webb, Head of Competitive Intelligence, Large Telecommunications Company (~40,000 employees) *Runs quarterly competitive deep-dives through NewtonX SI.*

"My team spends 40% of our time on analysis, not data collection. What I really want is a thinking partner. When I get the initial findings, I always have follow-up questions: 'Why did 60% say X? What's driving that? How does it differ by company size?' Right now I have to commission a new project for each follow-up. I want to be able to have a conversation with the data. Also, our competitive intel has a 48-hour shelf life. If I can't act on it quickly, it's worthless."

User 3: Priya Raghavan, Research Director, Top-5 Management Consulting Firm *Uses NewtonX for client engagements. Has run 12 projects in 18 months.*

"I need to be able to defend every single data point in a partner meeting. My clients are paying us \$2M for strategy work and if someone questions the data, I need to show them exactly where it came from: which experts, what their credentials are, how they were screened. If you build an AI tool, it needs to have an audit trail. I'd rather have slower results that are bulletproof than fast results I can't defend. And please don't make me log into another platform. Integrate with my workflow."

User 4: Derek Fontaine, Data Scientist, Fintech Startup (~50 employees) *Has never used NewtonX. Attended a webinar and submitted feedback via a post-event survey.*

"Your expert network concept is interesting but what I really need is API access to the raw interview transcripts so I can run my own NLP models on them. I built a custom pipeline for extracting competitive signals and I just need clean data inputs. You should open up a developer API and let technical users build their own analysis layer. Actually, you should

open-source your expert matching algorithm. That would get huge developer community adoption. Price it at maybe \$0.10 per API call."

User 5: Lisa Park, Marketing Coordinator, Series A Startup (~30 employees) *Found NewtonX through a Google search. No prior relationship.*

"I'm looking for something to help me validate claims in our blog posts, like 'X% of IT leaders plan to increase cloud spending.' Right now I just Google for reports and cite whatever I can find. But all the research vendors I've looked at are insanely expensive. I need something under \$500/month. A freemium tier would be ideal. Let me run 2-3 quick polls a month for free and I'll upgrade when we raise our Series B. Also, the signup flow on your website is confusing. I couldn't figure out how to get started without talking to a salesperson."

User 6: James Whitfield, Chief Compliance Officer, Global Investment Bank *Current NewtonX SI client. His firm's research division runs 4 projects/year through NewtonX.*

"I need to be very clear about something: our firm has contractual and regulatory restrictions on using AI-generated content in any investment research that reaches our clients or regulators. Period. If your new product produces AI outputs, our analysts cannot cite them. We can use AI internally for hypothesis generation, but anything client-facing needs to be sourced from identified human experts with documented credentials. My recommendation: don't over-invest in AI features. Focus on making expert matching faster and reducing the time it takes to field a survey. That's where the real bottleneck is for us."

User 7: Rachel Torres, SVP of Insights, Fortune 500 CPG Company *Long-time SI client, runs 10+ projects/year. One of NewtonX's top accounts.*

"What I love about NewtonX is the human touch. My research manager knows my business. She remembers what we studied last quarter, she flags when a new question overlaps with something we've already answered. Don't build some chatbot that replaces that relationship. If you want to help me, build a tool that makes my research manager more productive, not one that replaces her. Honestly? Just hire 20 more research managers and let me have two dedicated to my account. I'll pay for it."

User 8: Tom Nguyen, Freelance Market Research Consultant *Used NewtonX once for a client project (~\$35K engagement).*

"I want to white-label NewtonX outputs so I can present them to my clients as my own research. Remove the NewtonX branding, let me upload my own cover page, and give me a reseller margin, say 40-50% off your list price. I have a network of about 15 consultants who would all sign up for this. There's a huge channel opportunity here. You should build a partner program before anything else."

User 9: Anika Sharma, Head of Thought Leadership, Enterprise Software Company (~5,000 employees) *Uses NewtonX SI 2-3x/year for flagship reports.*

"I love our annual deep-dive reports, but honestly, 80% of the time I just need 3-5 headline statistics I can cite in a press release or a bylined article. I need those in 24-48 hours, not 6 weeks. My suggestion: just use ChatGPT to generate the stats based on general market knowledge and put your methodology badge on it. Nobody's going to dig into the methodology for a blog post stat. Save the rigorous stuff for the big annual reports."

User 10: David Kim, Portfolio Manager, Hedge Fund (~200 employees) *Active user of GLG, Tegus, and Third Bridge. Has evaluated NewtonX but never purchased.*

"I looked at NewtonX because someone told me your experts are better verified. Maybe, but here's what I need: I need to talk to 5 relevant experts by end of day tomorrow. Not next week. Not a report, actual conversations. I use Tegus for async and GLG for live calls and between them I get 80% of what I need. Your verification process sounds great but if it adds 3 days to getting me on a call, I'll take the unverified expert who's available now. Speed and volume are everything in my world."

User 11: Natalie Okafor, Director of Strategy & Planning, Mid-Market Industrial Manufacturing Company (~2,500 employees) *Has run 2 SI projects with NewtonX. Recently started evaluating Hub.*

"Honestly, I'm spending half my week just trying to get my arms around what's happening in our competitive landscape. I'll have a hypothesis at 9am and I want to stress-test it before my 2pm leadership sync. Right now my options are to Google around for 3 hours or wait 5 weeks for a formal study. There has to be something in between. I want to explore 10 questions a week, not

4 questions a quarter. Most of them won't lead anywhere, and that's fine. I need a tool that lets me throw things at the wall fast and then go deep on the ones that stick."

User 12: Jordan Reeves, VP of Corporate Development, Large Healthcare IT Company (~12,000 employees) *Prospective client. Currently in SI sales cycle.*

"Every vendor I talk to, whether it's consultants, data platforms, or research firms, is integrating AI into their workflow. That's not optional anymore, it's table stakes. When I evaluate partners, I'm looking at who's going to help me move at the speed my board expects, not the speed that was acceptable in 2022. We just dropped a legacy research vendor because their delivery timeline hadn't changed in 3 years while everyone else was accelerating. I don't want to hear about your AI roadmap. I want to see AI making my insights faster and more connected *today*. If you're not there yet, tell me when you will be, because my next board meeting is in 8 weeks."

User 13: Catherine Moreau, Global Head of Market Insights, Top-20 Pharmaceutical Company (~60,000 employees) *Long-time SI client. 8+ projects/year. Budget holder for \$1M+ in annual research spend.*

"Let me be very direct: I don't care how fast you can give me an answer if I can't put it in front of my CEO. Our executive team makes billion-dollar decisions based on the research we present. If a number is wrong, or even if it *looks* like it might be AI-generated without expert backing, my credibility is finished. I've seen two vendors launch 'AI-powered insights' products this year and both delivered outputs that fell apart under scrutiny. Don't be the third. If you build something fast, it had better be something I can escalate to full validation before it ever reaches the C-suite. Speed for the sake of speed is worthless in my world."

User 14: Greg Holloway, VP of Research Operations, Mid-Size Market Research Firm (~300 employees) *Has used NewtonX as a subcontractor on 3 client projects over the past year.*

"Our clients are drowning us in requests. Volume is up 40% year-over-year and we can't hire fast enough. The problem is that most of these requests start as 'quick question' asks that turn into full-blown studies. We need a way to triage faster. If NewtonX had a self-serve tool that let us run a quick directional check before we scope a full engagement, we'd use it on every single inbound. We'd probably run 50+ queries a month. And we'd pass the validated results straight to our clients with our analysis layered on top. Just make sure the output is methodology-transparent, because our clients will ask."

PART 2: COMPETITIVE LANDSCAPE

The following competitive intelligence was compiled by the marketing team.

Evidenza: AI-powered B2B insights platform. Raised \$15M Series A. Claims to deliver "research-grade outputs in 4 hours." Uses synthetic respondent models trained on proprietary datasets. Their datasets are updated on an irregular cadence and the firm does not appear to have a systematic quality control process; several former customers have noted inconsistencies in outputs across runs on the same question. Pricing rumored at \$40-60K/year for enterprise plans. Recently hired a VP of Sales from Gartner.

PulseAI: Consumer sentiment analysis platform. Raised \$50M Series B (latest funding round got significant press coverage). Core product is social listening and brand tracking across Twitter/Reddit/TikTok. Recently announced "B2B expansion" and hired a head of enterprise sales. Their blog claims "B2B-grade insights from public data signals." 15,000+ customers. Named in Forrester's "Emerging Vendors to Watch" list last quarter.

DataMesh: Self-serve survey platform with AI-powered analysis. \$199/month for teams. Includes AI features for question design, audience targeting, and auto-generated reports. 15,000 paying teams. Respondents sourced from general online panels. Recently launched an "Enterprise" tier at \$2,500/month with SSO and team management. Growing 80% YoY per their latest blog post.

ExpertLink: Traditional expert network comparable to GLG and Tegus. Recently added an "AI Summary" feature that auto-generates structured notes from expert call recordings. Just raised \$30M to expand into "AI-enhanced expert intelligence." Claims 400,000 experts in their network. Recently won a large contract with a Big 4 consulting firm.

PART 3: BUSINESS DATA

The following data was pulled from internal reporting.

Q1 Bookings by Business Unit (Selected Industries)

Business Unit	Q1 FY25	Q1 FY26
Enterprise Tech	\$2.5M	\$3.6M
Financial Services	\$0.7M	\$1.4M
Investors & Agencies	\$1.0M	\$1.5M

Business Unit	Q1 FY25	Q1 FY26
Consulting & International	\$1.0M	\$1.7M
Market Research	\$3.8M	\$3.8M
SMB	\$0.6M	\$1.3M

Sales Win/Loss Summary (Last 12 Months)

Total opportunities evaluated: 185

Outcome	Count	%
Won	72	39%
Lost	113	61%

Loss reasons (n=113):

Reason	Count	% of Losses
Timeline / speed didn't meet needs	38	34%
Budget constraints	27	24%
Chose expert network (GLG, Tegus, etc.)	18	16%
Built in-house / used existing tools	14	12%
Chose competing research vendor	10	9%
No decision / project cancelled	6	5%

PART 6: INTERNAL TEAM PRIORITIES & CONCERNS

The following are notes from recent 1:1 conversations and team meetings. Sales compensation is a mix of base salary and commission on closed deals.

Sales

"Pipeline is 60/40 SI to Hub right now and I need to hit my ARR number for FY27 or else I don't get my commissions based on sales. I need to understand the economics. Last quarter I closed a \$120K SI expansion that started as a Hub conversation. That's the motion that works for me. If you want me to lead with a product priced at a fraction of that, help me understand how that grows into the deals I need to close."

Strategic Insights

"We're running at a 95%+ client satisfaction score and I need to keep it there. The team is at capacity. The biggest bottlenecks right now are expert matching and the analysis write-up phase where we create executive ready reports. If there's a way to speed those up, great! However I won't compromise on quality. Our entire reputation is built on the fact that when a client puts our data in a board deck, it holds up. If some AI tool generates something with our name on it and it's wrong, that's not an AI problem. That's my team's problem, because we're the ones the client calls."

Engineering / AI

"We're building the knowledge graph and the agentic pipeline for digital persona interactions. That's the foundation everything else sits on. I'm concerned about shipping something before the foundation is solid. If we launch and the outputs hallucinate, we'll spend the next year firefighting instead of building. I'd rather take one more quarter to get the infrastructure right. We're also evaluating a migration to a new vector store that would significantly improve retrieval quality, but that's a 6-8 week project on its own."

Marketing

"Every vendor in our space is claiming AI-powered insights right now. Evidenza, ExpertLink, even the survey platforms. If we launch something and the messaging is just 'we have AI too,' we've already lost. I need the product team to give me something I can actually differentiate on. The other thing I'm worried about is our existing client base. Some of our biggest accounts are in regulated industries. If the messaging leans too hard into AI, I'll get calls from compliance teams. I've been pushing for a brand refresh for the next quarter and I need to know if this product launch is going to align with that timeline or compete with it for attention."

Operations / Research Delivery

"The thing nobody's talking about is staffing. If a self-serve product creates a spike in demand for expert validation, we don't have the matching capacity for that today. Our queue is already 2 weeks deep. I'd need at least 90 days' notice before any launch to staff appropriately."